

The Cadet Nurse Corps

The need for nurses during World War II motivated Congress to pass the Nursing Training Act of 1943. Franklin Delano Roosevelt brought the Cadet Nurse Corps into existence when he signed into law the Bolton Act, named for its original sponsor, Frances Payne Bolton (Congresswoman; Ohio), establishing the Cadet Nurse Corps of the Public Health Service.

Daryl Brown, PhD, RN

When Congress passed provisions of the Bolton Act on June 15, 1943, the United States Cadet Nurse Corps became the largest and youngest group of uniformed women to serve their country during World War II.

Under the terms of this act, the corps allotted federal funds to provide nursing students with free tuition, uniforms, room and board, and a monthly stipend. In exchange, they agreed to stay in either military or essential civilian nursing through the remainder of the war. For many young women, the Cadet Nurse Corps offered a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to get a baccalaureate degree. The corps was unusual because it represented the federal government's initial involvement in funding an educational experience for nurses. The Cadet Nurse Corps program graduated more than 124,000 nurses at a critical time in health care.

During its 3 years of existence, the Cadet Nurse Corps provided a great reservoir of trained nurses for the military and prevented the collapse of civilian nursing service on the home front. During World War II, the United States faced a crippling

shortage of skilled nurses as approximately 250,000 nurses, more than 20% of the nursing workforce, were sent to the front lines to care for Allied troops. As a result, by 1942, there was a massive shortage of civilian nurses in the U.S. The corps was able to fill this void with able and skilled young women eager to serve their country.

Army Surgeon General Norman T. Kirk stated in his tribute to the corps on its 50th anniversary, "... we should take time out to pay tribute to the dedicated group of women who promised to stay in nursing in service of their country for as long as was necessary to win the war that raged when they entered service. Their contribution was critical to the many young men for whom they cared. It was a contribution we should never forget. By stepping into uniform for their country, the Nurse Corps played an essential role in ending the war. They should be honored for their efforts."

(Continued on Page 6, The Cadet Nurse Corps)



Reception Honoring Cadet Nurses

The Cadet Nurse Corps

(Continued from Page 1)

Reception honors Cadet Nurses

On Friday, October 15, 2004 a reception honoring women who were members of the Cadet Nurse Corps took place at the Hartford Marriott Hotel as part of CNA's 98th Annual Convention. After presentation of colors, Linda Spoonster Schwartz, Commissioner of Veterans Affairs, gave greetings to the gathering, which included more than 25 nurses from the corps.

The nurses were invited to share their names, hospital affiliation, and remembrances with the attendees. The women were so willing to share with all of us a "memory" of their experiences with the Cadet Nurse Corps. Most of the women brought memorabilia to share, including pictures and patches from their uniforms.

All of the women spoke of the Cadet Nurse Corps as a "wonderful experience," as being proud to wear the uniform and that some "wore it everywhere they went." Most expressed gratitude to the Cadet Nurse Corps for it allowed them the opportunity to become a nurse.

The women of the corps worked in every area of nursing imaginable: pediatrics, nurse anesthetist, psychiatry, nurse educator, Peace Corps (in Chile, Puerto Rico, and Katmandu), private duty, staff nursing, doctor's office, director of nursing at a convalescent hospital, Public Health Department, obstetrics, nursery, Department of Corrections, V.A. Hospital, etc.

Some of the nurses from the Cadet Nurse Corps are still actively engaged in work e.g. nurse educator or volunteer services, e.g., Americares.

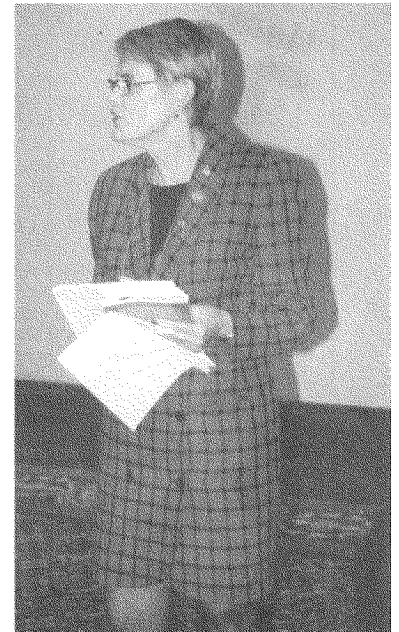
An overwhelming theme that ran through the reception was that the nurses from the Cadet Nurse Corps want to be recognized as veterans. One of the nurses told me that President Harry Truman had promised that the nurses would have veteran status, but to date, they have not received this. Another nurse who is very active in this pursuit asked the attendees to write or call their representatives to support. Bill HR 476 in the House and S1948 in the Senate.

At the end of the reception, Commissioner Schwartz was presented with a special commemorative framed picture of the World War II monument. Commissioner Schwartz presented the picture to the CNA. The picture is to be placed in the CNA Headquarters in Meriden, CT. Commissioner Schwartz invited the members of the Cadet Nurse Corps to become part of an oral history of veterans. She distributed forms for the nurses to sign up for the World War II Registry of Remembrances.

The colors were retired and the reception officially ended, but many of the nurses remained to share more stories and proud memories with their colleagues and friends. It was a very touching and wonderful event to witness.



Dee Lippman (l) introduces Commissioner Linda Spoonster Schwartz.



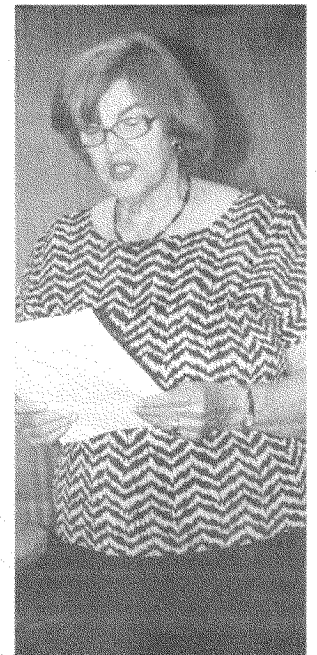
Dee Lippman



Ruth Rumley, cadet nurse.



Madelyn Flores-Smith, a cadet from Pennsylvania.



Joyce Hannan who traveled from Joliet, IL to be at the reception.



Commissioner Schwartz thanks the cadet nurses for their service.



Cadet nurse speaks to group about her experiences.

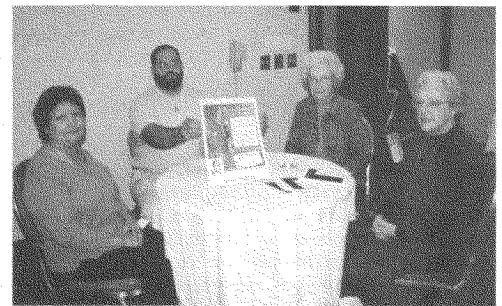


The color guard of the Veteran's Hospital in Rocky Hill presented the colors.

Reception Honoring Cadet Nurses

Over 20 nurses who traveled from as far away as Pennsylvania and Illinois attended the reception for cadet nurses.

Many remarked that they had never been honored.



Copyright (c) 2004, Connecticut Nurses' Association. □
Reprinted with permission.